

RESEARCH METHODS I IN PSYCHOLOGY

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TOPIC: ETHNOGRAPHY

OUTLINE:

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- A large, semi-transparent watermark of the PUACP logo is centered in the background. The logo is a shield-shaped emblem with a yellow border. Inside the shield, there is a blue stylized tree or plant motif. Above the tree, there is Arabic calligraphy in blue. Below the tree, the letters 'PUACP' are written in blue. A yellow banner with Arabic calligraphy is draped across the middle of the shield.

DEFINITION:

The study and systematic recording of human cultures. Also : a descriptive work produced from such research.

Ethnography is a qualitative method for collecting data often used in the social and behavioural sciences. Data are collected through observations and interviews, which are then used to draw conclusions about how societies and individuals function.

It is a type of qualitative research that involves immersing yourself in a particular community or organization to observe their behavior and interactions up close.

Example: A classic example of ethnographic research would be an anthropologist traveling to an island, living within the society on said island for years, and researching its people and culture through a process of sustained observation and participation.

- **Types:**

There are two main types of ethnographic research, depending on how it is conducted: relational and digital. These types of ethnography enable researchers to learn about the language, culture, social relationships, food availability, and habits of people that may not have been studied before.

- **Objective:**

The primary purpose of ethnography is to gain a holistic understanding of a social or cultural group.

- **Scope:**

Ethnography addresses ethnographic findings and methods in a broad interdisciplinary understanding of culture, domination and social structure.

LITERATURE REVIEW:

A literature review provides an overview of the scholarly literature (e.g. books, articles, dissertations, proceedings) relevant to an area of research or theory. The review typically includes a summary of the major questions in an area and critical evaluations of previous work. Literature reviews are also helpful for their comprehensive bibliographies.

A literature review in ethnography within psychology typically involves examining existing research, theories, and methodologies related to studying human behavior and culture in naturalistic settings. Here's a detailed breakdown of what it entails:

- **Introduction:**

Define ethnography in the context of psychology.

Explain the importance of studying behavior in natural settings.

Provide an overview of the purpose and scope of the literature review.

- **Theoretical Framework:** Present key theories and concepts in ethnography, such as cultural psychology, social constructivism, and symbolic interactionism. Discuss how these theories inform the study of human behavior in specific cultural contexts.
- **Methodological Approaches:** Review various ethnographic methods used in psychological research, such as participant observation, interviews, and document analysis. Discuss the strengths and limitations of each method and how they contribute to understanding cultural phenomena.
- **Historical Perspectives:** Trace the development of ethnography in psychology, highlighting seminal studies and researchers in the field. Discuss shifts in methodology and theoretical perspectives over time.
- **Cross-Cultural Research:** Examine studies that compare cultural practices, beliefs, and behaviours across different societies. Discuss findings related to cultural universals, cultural relativism, and cultural variation..
- **Applied Ethnography:** Explore how ethnographic methods are applied in various psychological domains, such as clinical psychology, organizational psychology, and educational psychology. Highlight examples of research that have used ethnography to address real-world problems or inform interventions.
- **Ethical Considerations:** Address ethical issues related to conducting ethnographic research, such as informed consent, confidentiality, and cultural sensitivity. Discuss strategies for navigating ethical dilemmas in cross-cultural research.
- **Current Trends and Future Directions:** Identify emerging topics and methodologies in ethnography within psychology. Discuss potential areas for future research and theoretical advancements.
- **Conclusion:** Summarize key findings from the literature review. Discuss the implications of existing research for understanding human behavior in cultural context. Offer suggestions for future research directions and the importance of continued inquiry in ethnography within psychology.

Throughout the review, it's essential to critically analyze and synthesize the literature, identifying patterns, inconsistencies, and gaps in the existing research. Additionally, providing clear and concise explanations of complex concepts and methodologies is crucial for readers to understand the breadth and depth of the field.

FEATURES OF ETHNOGRAPHY:

Ethnography is a qualitative method which is used to study about cultures and norms. There are many important features of Ethnography. Such as it is relate with the participant observation, long term engagement and also relate with holistic approach.

Hammersley and Atkinson put emphasis on the these features and also explain that ethnography is relate with the Inductive analysis and cultural sensitivity.

Inductive analysis : The researchers put emphasis on inductive analysis in ethnography because theories emerge during the field study.

Cultural sensitivity : The ethnographers must be sensitive to study the cultural context and norms of the culture and try to minimize the harms.

Some other features are explained below:

- **Emphasis on exploration:** Ethnography is a method which strongly emphasis on exploring the new phenomenon rather than emphasis on data collection
- **Tendency toward unstructured data:** Ethnography is mostly relate with the unstructured data during the research .Such as mostly researchers prefer to use Audio recording ,videos and pictures to collect the data.
- **Investigation method:** In ethnography researchers mostly investigate a small number of sample rather than a big sample.

For example Researchers try to collect data by using observation and focus group so they try to collect it from a small sample.

- **Analysis of Data:** Researchers in ethnography try to interpret data in the form of coding. In ethnography researchers do not use the statistic methods to interpret the data .They interpret data in the form of coding which they can easily recall the data.

Ethnography mostly relate with the informal interviews.This method comes from a anthropology at start .But now this method is going to be very common day by day .

It is also used in the sociology, education and also become common in psychology.

At start this method is used in the report area for data collection.

Such as tribal or criminal information .

But now this method is used in the routine life

Now, this method is called the **institutional ethnography**.

It is used to conduct the different experiment on people such as “ **homeless adolescence**” experiment of flick on their health issues is the example of ethnography in psychology.

Some other **3 features given by Luders** and these are given below.

- **Unplanned situations:**

Ethnography is very important in the unplanned situations . It helps in the difficult situations such as in the data collection from criminal . The ethnographer must have to prepare in all the unplanned or critical situation during the research.

- **Researcher Skills:**

In ethnography researchers skills plays an important role because in this method researcher skills are highly required to cope with every situation.

- **Multiple method of data collection:**

Ethnography is the method in which we use the different methods for data collection such as

- Observation
- Interviews
- Focus group
- Document analysis

METHODOLOGY:

Ethnographic research may use one or more research methods depending on the field, the size of the sample, and the research goal. There are usually five main ways to do ethnographic research:

Naturalism,

Participant observation,

Interviews,

Surveys, and

Research in archives.

1. Naturalism

Naturalism, also known as live and work ethnography research, involves observing research variables in their natural context to identify and record behavioural patterns. It may include spending time in the group's natural habitat to record their activities.

Naturalism, the oldest ethnographic research method, may build rapport between the ethnographer and the variables. The researcher must minimize subject interference to get the most objective results when utilizing this method.

Undisguised naturalistic observation is possible. In disguised naturalistic observation, people are ignorant of being examined, but in undisguised observation, they are aware.

Observing subjects in their native environment in the life and work technique yields the most accurate and relevant data. Modern ethnographers, especially in health and education, avoid this method since it is expensive and time-consuming.

2. Participant observation:

Participant observation in ethnography research involves the ethnographer actively interacting with the research subjects. This method resembles life and work. Participant observation differs from live and naturalistic in that the ethnographer participates in the group. The researcher gets group-only information.

Disguised and undisguised participant observation exists. The ethnographer disguises himself as a research subject in the former.

In undisguised participant observation, the ethnographer joins the gathering and discloses their researcher status. This method is different from hidden participant observation in that it is reactive. Participant observation gives ethnographers more data. They better understand the research subjects' experiences and habits from the participant's perspective.

This research method is limited. First, the researcher's presence can influence research subjects' conduct, especially in undisguised participant observation, which might skew results. "Research bias" is another concern. Due to their interaction with the group, ethnographers may become less objective, which can lead to experimental bias and impact research results.

3. Interviews

Ethnographic interviews combine profound observation with one-on-one discussions to produce the most authentic research results. The ethnographer talks to the research group while conducting research-related activities in this design.

This contextual inquiry collects data about the research group's goals and behavior. The ethnographer might ask questions about the research group while observing it in its natural habitat.

The researcher's relationship with the interviewees frequently leads to an informal, spontaneous ethnographic interview. Participant observation often leads to the ethnographic interview when the ethnographer interacts with the research group to learn about their life.

An ethnographic interview, a two-way research approach, lets the researcher get the most relevant and authentic information from the research group. However, ethnographer-subject relationships can cause experimental bias.

4. Surveys

Ethnography surveys are inductive research methods used to learn about the issue. Analytic induction is a research design that uses survey questions to test hypotheses.

A survey will assist the ethnographer in obtaining data, analyzing it, and reaching objective conclusions. Analytic induction seeks to identify the causes of the research group's habits and provide reliable explanations.

Use multiple question types in your survey to get the most relevant results. Likert scale, open-ended, multiple-choice, and close-ended ethnography survey questions are prevalent.

Survey response bias and high drop-out rates are important drawbacks of this research strategy. However, this strategy is fast and cost-effective online and can give significant insights about a research group.

5. Research in archives

Archival research is a qualitative ethnographic research method that evaluates existing research, records, and other sources concerning the research group to find useful information. Understanding describes this process.

Archival research uses ethnography to research connected historical materials in place of physical presence. It analyzes all research variable data.

Since the ethnographer does not have contact with the subjects, archive research lowers experimental biases. The ethnographer can also use a huge data set for more accurate findings.

Archival research may misrepresent the research group due to randomization. Archival data may be biased, affecting research results.

RESEARCH PROCESS:

1. Research Problem Formulation: The research problem in ethnography is typically formulated based on a desire to understand social phenomena within their cultural context. This involves identifying a topic of interest that requires an in-depth exploration of behaviours, beliefs, and interactions within a specific community or cultural group.

- Researchers often engage in a process of immersion and observation to identify potential research problems. This may involve spending time in the field, participating in community activities, and building rapport with community members to gain insights into their lived experiences and challenges.

- The research problem should be open-ended and flexible, allowing for emergent themes and unexpected findings to shape the direction of the study. It should also be culturally sensitive, reflecting an understanding of the cultural nuances and complexities of the community under study.

2. Sampling:

- Ethnographic sampling involves selecting participants who can provide valuable insights into the research problem and represent the diversity of the cultural context.
- Theoretical sampling is a key concept in ethnography, introduced by sociologist Barney Glaser and grounded theorist Anselm Strauss. It involves the iterative process of selecting new participants and collecting data based on emerging theoretical insights from ongoing data analysis.
- Theoretical sampling aims to saturate emerging theoretical categories or concepts with relevant data, refining and elaborating theoretical explanations as the study progresses.
- Unlike traditional sampling methods, which aim for representativeness or generalizability, theoretical sampling focuses on theoretical relevance and the generation of grounded theory.
- Researchers continuously assess their emerging theories and hypotheses, selecting new participants and data sources to further develop and validate their theoretical explanations.

3. Implementation of Theoretical Sampling:

- The process of theoretical sampling typically unfolds in several stages:
- **Initial data collection:** Researchers begin by collecting data from a diverse range of participants and sources to explore the research problem and generate initial theoretical insights.
- **Data analysis:** Researchers analyze the collected data to identify patterns, themes, and theoretical concepts. This involves coding, categorizing, and comparing data to develop theoretical explanations.
- **Theoretical sampling:** Based on the emerging theoretical insights, researchers select new participants and data sources that can provide additional information to further develop and refine the theoretical framework.
- **Iterative data collection and analysis:** The process of theoretical sampling continues iteratively, with researchers collecting new data, analyzing it, and revising their theoretical explanations until theoretical saturation is reached.

INTERPRETATION:

Interpretation in ethnography involves making sense of qualitative data collected through methods such as participant observation, interviews, and document analysis. Coding is a crucial method used in interpretation to systematically analyze and categorize the data. Here's an explanation of interpretation using coding in ethnography:

1. **Data Immersion:** Before coding begins, researchers immerse themselves in the data to gain familiarity with its content. This involves reviewing field notes, transcripts, recordings, and any other data collected during fieldwork.
2. **Open Coding:** The coding process typically starts with open coding, where researchers analyze the data line by line to identify and label concepts, themes, or patterns. Each piece of data is assigned a descriptive code that represents its content or meaning. Open coding allows for the exploration of diverse perspectives and phenomena without predefined categories.
3. **Axial Coding:** After generating a set of initial codes, researchers engage in axial coding to organize and connect them into broader categories or themes. Axial coding involves examining relationships between codes and identifying commonalities or connections across different segments of data. This process helps to develop a more structured and coherent understanding of the data.
4. **Selective Coding:** In the final stage of coding, known as selective coding, researchers focus on refining and consolidating the most significant themes or categories that emerged during open and axial coding. This involves identifying core concepts or central themes that capture the essence of the data and provide a framework for interpretation.
5. **Constant Comparison:** Throughout the coding process, researchers engage in constant comparison, comparing new data to previously coded data to identify similarities, differences, and relationships. This iterative process ensures the consistency and reliability of coding decisions and facilitates the discovery of emergent patterns or variations within the data.
6. **Memo Writing:** In addition to coding, researchers often write memos or reflective notes to document their thoughts, insights, and interpretations throughout the analysis process. Memos serve as a tool for capturing ideas, making connections between codes, and generating hypotheses or theoretical insights. They also help researchers to maintain reflexivity and transparency by documenting their analytical decisions and thought processes.
7. **Thematic Analysis:** Once coding is complete, researchers engage in thematic analysis to identify overarching themes or patterns that cut across the data. This involves organizing coded segments into meaningful clusters based on shared characteristics or relationships. Thematic analysis allows researchers to distill the richness of the data into coherent narratives or explanations that address the research questions or objectives.
8. **Member Checking:** To enhance the validity and trustworthiness of interpretations, researchers may engage in member checking by presenting their findings to participants for validation or feedback. Member checking allows participants to

confirm the accuracy of interpretations, provide additional insights, or correct any misunderstandings. This collaborative approach ensures that interpretations are grounded in the perspectives and experiences of those being studied.

LIMITATIONS:

1. **Limited generalizability:** Findings from ethnographic studies are often specific to the particular group or community being studied and may not be applicable to a larger population.
2. **Subjectivity and bias:** Ethnographers bring their own perspectives and biases into the research process, which can influence the interpretation of data and potentially introduce bias.
3. **Time-consuming:** Ethnographic research requires significant time and resources as it involves prolonged engagement and observation within the community, making it a lengthy process.
4. **Limited sample size:** Ethnographic studies typically focus on a small group or community, which may not represent the diversity or complexity of the larger population.
5. **Ethical challenges:** Ethnographers must navigate ethical considerations such as informed consent, privacy, and the potential impact on the community being studied.
6. **Interpretation challenges:** Analyzing and interpreting qualitative data from ethnographic research can be complex and subjective, leading to potential discrepancies in findings.
7. **Limited control over variables:** Ethnographic research often takes place in natural settings, making it challenging to control external variables that may influence the research outcomes.
8. **Multiple data collection methods:** There is no emphasis on particular data collection methods because of multiple methods are available and researcher prefer on the basis of availability.

These limitations highlight the need for researchers to carefully consider the scope and applicability of ethnographic findings while recognizing the valuable insights it can provide into specific cultural contexts.

